

## 27, Utilizing Buddhism as a Paradigm to Illustrate the Transformation of Social Thought During the Feudalization Process

Previously, the impact of *feudalization* (封建化) upon *social consciousness* and its influence on the dissemination of religions have been explicated in a dispersed manner. Here, taking the historical regions where Buddhism (佛教) propagated as our scope of observation, we will centrally elucidate this point through the history of Buddhism itself and its competition with other religions.

The geographical expanse where Buddhism historically flourished encompasses *South Asia* (南亚), East Asia (东亚), *Southeast Asia* (东南亚), and portions of *Central Asia* (中亚). This macro-region still houses half of the global population today, and it commanded an even more staggering proportion in antiquity. Therefore, utilizing Buddhism as the primary narrative thread to investigate the evolution of feudal thought is highly representative.

Like Jainism (耆那教), Buddhism was birthed during the terminal phase of the *Great Expansion* (大扩张时代) era, which simultaneously constituted the formative period of the *classical period* (古典时代). Although the *religious doctrines* (教义) of these two religions undeniably possess the intense personal characteristics of their founders and prominent disciples, the prevalence of Buddhism and Jainism was definitively the product of their congruence with the demands of societal development.

Examples include their fierce opposition to the rigid caste system (种姓制度) of Brahmanism (婆罗门教), their critique of hyper-complex and astronomically costly sacrifices, their profound emphasis on the efficacy of individual effort (*achieving liberation [解脱] through ascetic cultivation, representing, of course, conditional free will*), the ideology of non-violence, their adaptation to commercial ethics (*advocating honesty and frugality*), and the capacity of the monastic order (僧团) to provide tangible assistance to commercial communities.

These novel religious concepts mirrored the profound mutations in *social consciousness* since the *Great Expansion* and were monumentally conducive to the construction of a *classical society* (古典社会); consequently, they were universally embraced across multiple social strata. Naturally, they also garnered the immense favor of the rulers. After all, during the formative process of *classical empires* (古典帝国), newly ascendant monarchs were definitively not going to harbor amicable attitudes toward Brahmin priests (婆罗门祭司). Not only were these monarchs themselves highly likely to originate from lower-caste groups, but to aggressively augment their *despotic power* (专制权力), it was fundamentally necessary to weaponize novel religions that critiqued the caste system.

This point is utterly decisive because Brahmanism or Hinduism (印度教) could entirely mutate into forms conducive to deifying autocratic monarchs; for instance, one clearly observes this exact adaptation within the Khmer Empire (高棉帝国). However, regardless of adaptations, Brahmanism and Hinduism ultimately struggle to repudiate the caste concepts deeply embedded within their own doctrines, nor can they negate the fundamental role of Brahmin priests. For monarchs attempting to maximize their *despotic power*, this was ultimately less politically convenient than Mahayana Buddhism (大乘佛教).

During the formative period of classical India (古典印度), the rulers of the various Indian states manifested intense interest in and support for the Śramaṇa (沙门思潮) ideological currents opposing Brahmanism. The capability of Buddhism to distinguish itself among the multitude of Śramaṇa

currents was inextricably linked to specific doctrines and **religious laws** (教法) inherent to Buddhism itself. For instance, the practices of accepting alms and maintaining celibacy clearly signaled to rulers that the Sangha (僧伽团体) was a relatively easily controllable religious group.

Naturally, when Shakyamuni (释迦牟尼) propagated the profound wisdom he had awakened to, it is highly probable that his objective was not the genesis of a formal religious organization. Early Buddhism resembled a philosophical school far more closely, much like the various philosophical sects of ancient Greece. Therefore, although this ideology—predicated upon personal epiphany—inevitably possessed cognitive elements aligning with societal development (*precisely because Shakyamuni himself was born in that specific era*), it was ultimately not a religious ideology specifically engineered to support a **classical society**.

However, the foundational ideological concepts and the organization of the monastic order established during Shakyamuni's era destined Buddhism to metamorphose into a formal religion. After all, it had already laid a robust foundation and secured a definitive foothold within society. Following the passing of Shakyamuni, Buddhism rapidly fractured into myriad sects. Concurrently, through the relentless filtering process of social reality, a specific Buddhist sect calling itself "Mahayana Buddhism" surged to prominence within classical India.

Today, Chinese Buddhism remains predominantly Mahayana Buddhism. Mahayana Buddhism refers to the Buddhist sects opposing it as "Hinayana Buddhism" (小乘佛教), which is patently a pejorative designation. Adherents of Hinayana Buddhism generally consider themselves to belong to "Theravada Buddhism" (上座部佛教); in China, because the regions where Theravada Buddhism is prevalent are situated in the south, it is colloquially referred to as Southern Buddhism (南传佛教).

Buddhist sects differ in no substantive way from the sects of any other religion: every faction frantically attempts to proclaim that it alone represents the authentic, genuine Dharma (佛法) existing since the era of Shakyamuni. The specific historical reality is exceedingly difficult to ascertain today. Interestingly, however, due to the disparate historical developmental trajectories of East Asia and **Southeast Asia**, we can clearly discern from the doctrines and **religious laws** of the Mahayana and Theravada Buddhism existing today that the core distinction between these two ideologies does not lie in the magnitude of their philosophical divergence. Rather, it lies in the fact that they adapted to entirely different stages of social reality:

**Mahayana Buddhism was the state religion of classical society, whereas Theravada Buddhism is the feudal religion (封建宗教) of feudal society (封建社会).**

Next, let us examine where the exact differences between these two forms of Buddhism lie. In fact, merely enumerating their core distinctions renders the reality immediately self-evident.

- Theravada Buddhism pursues the Arhat (阿罗汉) as its ultimate goal of cultivation, relentlessly seeking individual Nirvana (涅槃); Mahayana Buddhism pursues the Bodhisattva (菩萨) as its ultimate goal, seeking to enable all sentient beings to attain Nirvana.
- Theravada Buddhism profoundly emphasizes the aspect of the Buddha primarily as a teacher/guide; Mahayana Buddhism fiercely emphasizes the absolute divinity of the Buddha.
- Theravada Buddhism emphasizes that through one's own strenuous effort, adhering strictly to the Buddha's teachings in cultivation leads to the attainment of the Arhat; Mahayana

Buddhism intensely emphasizes altruism (利他)—one must not only attain liberation for oneself but must also assist all sentient beings in achieving liberation.

- The rituals of Theravada Buddhism are relatively spartan, emphasizing solitary cultivation and profound reverence for the Buddha; the rituals of Mahayana Buddhism are exceptionally labyrinthine, encompassing sutra chanting, elaborate offerings, and grand Dharma assemblies (法会).
- Theravada Buddhism heavily emphasizes the cultivation and liberation of monastics (出家人), and the monastic order is rigorously organized and deeply entrenched among the common populace; Mahayana Buddhism postulates that lay practitioners (居家信徒) can identically cultivate to elevated realms, rendering the monastic order relatively less rigorous and its connection with the grassroots populace comparatively superficial.
- In scriptural exegesis (释经), Theravada Buddhism strongly inclines toward literal interpretation; conversely, Mahayana Buddhism exhibits phenomenal flexibility in interpreting scriptures.
- Theravada Buddhism fundamentally dislikes expedient means (方便法门) in cultivation, fiercely emphasizing strict adherence to the precepts (戒律); whereas Mahayana Buddhism explicitly permits the utilization of diverse expedient means to guide sentient beings of varying fundamental capacities toward cultivation.

In fact, through such an enumeration, readers who have reached this point will naturally understand why Mahayana Buddhism (大乘佛教) is deemed a religion of the **classical period**, whereas Theravada Buddhism (上座部佛教) is considered a *feudal religion* (封建宗教).

However, for people outside of so-called communist countries—especially those in developed democratic nations like Europe, America, and Japan—it is exceedingly difficult to comprehend the ingenuity behind the concept of the Bodhisattva (菩萨) "saving all sentient beings" ("普度众生") in Mahayana Buddhism. Those who do not understand the underlying rationale easily assume this is a sublime moral quality, representing an intense spirit of self-sacrifice. Yet I wish to state that the so-called universal salvation of sentient beings by Bodhisattvas is, in every sense, of the exact same nature as 20th-century dictators emphasizing that their exceptional leadership could save the nation.

When Mahayana Buddhist theory validates that an individual can cultivate to become a Bodhisattva to save all sentient beings, it simultaneously cannot deny that this person's physical morphology in reality bears no difference from that of ordinary humans. However, once we regard him as a highly virtuous "Bodhisattva" and postulate that a minuscule minority possesses the superhuman capability to help the vast majority achieve liberation (解脱), we *de facto* acknowledge a colossal asymmetry among individuals.

This is precisely the implicit meaning of the phrase "I can liberate you." This not only expresses that "I" possess a moral superiority, but additionally implies that "I" occupy a dominant position in terms of power. In reality, if one comprehends the actions of despotic monarchs in East Asia who devoutly believed in or weaponized Buddhism, one would absolutely not overlook this point. These rulers frequently participated in religious activities precisely in the identity of a "Bodhisattva."

Right up to China's final imperial regime, namely the Qing Dynasty (清朝), the emperor, when facing regions deeply devoted to Tibetan Buddhism (藏传佛教) such as Tibet (藏地) and Mongolia (蒙古), was still regarded as the incarnation of Bodhisattva Manjushri (文殊菩萨). We have every reason to conclude that it was precisely this ideology—endowing the despotic monarch with divinity and ruling legitimacy—that constituted the foundation for Mahayana Buddhism's broad support (*from rulers*) within **classical society** (古典社会).

Therefore, from the 1st to the 7th century AD, Mahayana Buddhism catapulted to become the mainstream of Buddhism. This was exactly the golden age of **classical society** in the **South Asia** (南亚) region. The first entity to play a monumental role in propelling the development of Mahayana Buddhism was the Kushan Empire (贵霜帝国), a **classical empire** reliant on international trade; Buddhism's inherent support for commerce and urban civilization was already exceptionally robust. Moreover, the Mahayana Buddhist concept of Bodhisattvas saving all sentient beings was simply too irresistible for rulers seeking to elevate their personal image and authority. It is no wonder that the formidable sovereign Kanishka I (迦腻色伽一世) is revered by Buddhism as one of its most paramount monarchs.

The Kushan Empire's greatest contribution to Mahayana Buddhism lay in sculptural art (*stating it this way seems somewhat peculiar, as Mahayana Buddhism itself was highly likely formed precisely under the patronage of the Kushan Empire*). Both the rulers and the Buddhas, now regarded as divine deities, could project their supreme majesty through colossal statues. During the reign of the Gupta Dynasty (笈多王朝), the rulers supported the construction and continuously sponsored the Nalanda Monastery (那烂陀寺), which later became a massive academic center for Mahayana Buddhism. During this period, Mahayana Buddhism developed phenomenally complex philosophy, the speculativeness of which is sufficient to leave the world marveling even today. When Master Xuanzang (玄奘法师) traveled west to this location, what he hoped to learn was precisely this outstanding ideology.

One must not forget that the **classical period**, as a segment of the human historical process, inevitably engendered ideologies reflecting its temporal characteristics that possessed profound complexity. Likewise, Mahayana Buddhism could not possibly have been merely an ideology exclusively fronting for monarchical despotism; it possessed numerous commendable attributes.

Beginning in the 6th century AD, **classical society** in Northern India (北印度) commenced its regression. Logically speaking, Mahayana Buddhism was losing the foundation for survival in its birthplace at this time. Dramatically, however, although the **feudalization** process in Northern India had already begun to flourish, the Bengal region (孟加拉地区) did not follow suit. Today, the entire Bengal region (*encompassing Bangladesh [孟加拉国] and West Bengal [西孟加拉邦]*) houses over 250 million people, but geographically, this is ultimately the northeastern corner of the Indian subcontinent (印度次大陆). Its development occurred relatively late, particularly in the present-day territory of Bangladesh, which was densely covered in swamps and crisscrossed by rivers.

This chronological lag can be earliest observed through the timing of the appearance of Northern Indian pottery cultures across various locales. In a word, the historical trajectory of Bengali society was later than that of the vast majority of the Ganges River (恒河流域) basin right from its starting phase. Just as **classical society** in Northern India marched toward decline, the Pala Empire (波罗王朝), rising in the Bengal region, was precisely entering the zenith of a **classical empire**.

The agricultural conditions of Bengal itself were by no means poor, and early feudal regimes held no advantage relative to **classical empires**. Thus, the Pala Empire was able to expand into a massive empire, specifically conquering the epicenter of Buddhism, the former Kingdom of Magadha (摩揭陀国). The Pala Empire naturally continued to support Mahayana Buddhism, a state religion already highly adapted to the **classical period**. However, the overarching **feudalization** process of India was fundamentally unstoppable. Therefore, during the reign of the Pala Empire, Mahayana Buddhism underwent a critical mutation: Tantricism (密宗化).

We mentioned previously that during the regressive phase of a **classical society** (古典社会), rulers frequently exhaust every conceivable method to augment their **despotic power** (专制性权力) to compensate for the inevitable loss of **infrastructural power** (基础性权力); therefore, seeking mysticism as a means to deify themselves is phenomenally normal.

From the perspective of the rulers' demands, this is indeed one reason why Tantrism (密宗) began to occupy the mainstream of Mahayana Buddhism (大乘佛教). After all, colossal monasteries required state patronage, and the demands of the patron would inevitably exert a guiding influence. Furthermore, when its own doctrines and **religious laws** became increasingly incongruent with the demands of temporal development, one of the few forces a religion could place its hopes upon was precisely the monarch intent on weaponizing it; this mutual clinging for survival aligned squarely with the interests of both parties at that time.

However, even from the intrinsic perspective of Mahayana Buddhism itself, Tantricism (密宗化) was equally inevitable. As a religion that formed and developed during the **classical period**, early Mahayana Buddhism had already evolved characteristics adapted to **classical society**, such as rationalism, ideological pluralism, and an emphasis on philosophical speculation. In classical India (古典印度), massive religious debates were phenomenally common. Even if rulers genuinely favored Mahayana Buddhism, it was impossible for them to venerate it exclusively, because the absolute bedrock of a **classical empire** lay in factional equilibrium. To secure an advantage in this competition, Mahayana Buddhism was structurally compelled to develop colossal, centralized academic centers dedicated to intensifying logical and dialectical training, accompanied by an exceptionally complex monastic organization.

Yet, by the time of the Pala Empire's (波罗王朝) ascension, although the **social being** (社会存在) of Bengal (孟加拉国) could sustain this **classical empire**, other regions of India—particularly Northern India—had ultimately already **feudalized** (封建化). This precipitated a dynamic where Mahayana Buddhism's competitors began spontaneously mutating toward **feudal religions** (封建宗教). Most notably, Brahmanism (婆罗门教)—the indigenous religion with an ancient history precisely on the Indian subcontinent—essentially completed its transmutation into Hinduism (印度教).

Feudalized religions massively invested their attention into the social grassroots: the worship of principal deities was established, pilgrimage systems developed, and local deities were subsumed (*frequently, local goddesses appeared in the avatar of the wives of principal Hindu deities, which squarely met the demand for the emergence of national consciousness during the **feudal period**, especially in Southern India*). Hindu temples began to assume the function of facilitating economic circulation within **feudal society**. Outside the territories of the Pala Empire, Hinduism, having thoroughly adapted to the realities of **feudalization**, repelled Buddhism across virtually the entire subcontinent.

This is not to imply that Hindu clerics abandoned debating Buddhist monks. Yet the era had undeniably mutated; Hinduism naturally still needed to prove its rectitude through debate, but this was no longer its primary imperative. For Mahayana Buddhism, it now possessed gargantuan academic institutions like the Nalanda Monastery (那烂陀寺) in vain, yet found itself "drawing its sword and looking around in bewilderment" ("拔剑四顾心茫然"); the rules of the game had fundamentally altered.

The organizational apparatus of a religion, having developed over several centuries, possesses its own terrifying inertia even if it no longer suits contemporary development. By the tail end of the first millennium AD, even if the Pala Empire still maintained the façade of a **classical empire**, within an increasingly **feudalizing** era, what rationale could massive and labyrinthine academic institutions like Nalanda Monastery, Vikramashila (超戒寺), and Odantapuri (飞行寺) possibly seek to justify their continued existence?

Tantrism provided an answer that appeared relatively rational at the time. First, Tantrism inherently absorbed certain consciousness of **feudal religion**; more so than any other sect, it emphasized the application of expedient means (方便法门 / i.e., "shortcuts" in cultivation) during cultivation, largely shattering the precepts and even weaponizing secular desires for cultivation. However, in stark contrast to **feudal religions**, Tantrism emphasized "control" over these cultivation shortcuts. It codified a suite of excruciatingly cumbersome mystical rituals and astronomically costly offering methods. This ensured that while commoners could still gaze upon the Buddha's ideology, achieving an exceptionally elevated realm of cultivation was fundamentally impossible for them.

Tantrism drastically reinforced the status of the Guru (上师), demanding absolute obedience and devotion to the Guru; in the absence of their guidance, success in esoteric cultivation was virtually impossible. Since the path of cultivation possessed a "Zhongnan shortcut" (终南捷径), yet such a shortcut was utterly impassable without a guide—and even with a guide, one was compelled to invest monumental energy and even wealth to decipher those mystical mantras and complete the labyrinthine religious rituals—the massive academic centers of Mahayana Buddhism forged during the **classical period** naturally found a renewed justification for their continued existence.

Simultaneously, the rulers identically derived satisfaction for their spiritual and political demands from this ideological mutation. Because only individuals possessing elevated social status could possibly complete the rituals and offerings, this undeniably fortified the rulers' superiority in identity.

The prosperity of the Pala Empire could not endure eternally. After 1000 AD, even the **classical society** of Bengal was marching toward its termination. On the eve of the Turkic Muslim invasions, Hindu regimes briefly regained supremacy in Bengal; however, by the 13th century, Islamic conquerors arrived here. Because the history of the Bengal region commenced relatively late, exactly when the Islamic regime conquered this area, the local **feudalization** process in Bengal was just nascent. Islam (伊斯兰教), in turn, is a religion that exhibits profound congruence with early **feudal society**.

Consequently, in Bengal, Islam was able to gradually secure the support of the broad populace over centuries of rule, and came to be perceived as a mechanism to preserve Bengal's own independence within the vast ocean of Hinduism. Among the Chinese people, there frequently exists a prejudice asserting that Islam is a "religion of the desert," maximally suited for dissemination in arid and

semi-arid regions. However, the histories of Bengal and maritime **Southeast Asia** conspicuously negate this premise. Climate and topography do not directly dictate where Islam can or cannot take root; the genuinely decisive factor is permanently the local historical and social trajectory.

Today, taking India as the boundary, one discovers that the so-called Northern Buddhism (北传佛教) is fundamentally Mahayana Buddhism (大乘佛教), while Southern Buddhism (南传佛教) is fundamentally Theravada Buddhism (上座部佛教). This phenomenon is not accidental.

During the ascendance of Mahayana Buddhism, the entirety of the Eurasian continent was still ruled by several formidable regimes which, despite differing in their respective stages, could all be classified as **classical empires** (古典帝国). Furthermore, trade and international exchange were primarily conducted via the overland Silk Road (丝绸之路). When **feudalization** (封建化) had already swept across the vast majority of the Eurasian continent, the arteries of international trade shifted to the Maritime Silk Road (海上丝绸之路) across the Mediterranean, the Indian Ocean, and the Western Pacific.

Even so, the entity that first achieved victory in **Southeast Asia**—alongside Brahmanism (婆罗门教)—was still not the feudal Theravada Buddhism, but remained Mahayana Buddhism. For regions such as Cambodia (柬埔寨), Sumatra (苏门答腊), and Java (爪哇), the various conditions were insufficient to enable them to transition directly from an **early state** (早期国家) into a **feudal society** (封建社会). Even though the main arteries of international trade passed through **Southeast Asia**, in terms of absolute distance, it was still far too distant from India and China.

During the five centuries from 1000 AD to the arrival of the Europeans, the **classical society** (古典社会) of the Indochinese Peninsula (中南半岛) and maritime **Southeast Asia** (海岛东南亚) (*although the latter was relatively primitive*) was disintegrating. Theravada Buddhism gained the favor of the "barbarians" (蛮族) from the north, ultimately securing ideological dominance over the Indochinese Peninsula with the exception of Vietnam (越南). Concurrently, Islam (伊斯兰教), propagating alongside commerce, was embraced by various Austronesian peoples (南岛各民族) and ultimately secured dominance over maritime **Southeast Asia**.

Although Vietnam retained certain bureaucratic systems (官僚制度) originating from China, it historically took Mahayana Buddhism as its primary religion (*I do not regard Confucianism [儒家思想] as a religion*). However, for a prolonged period following its independence from China, its degree of **feudalization** was not low. The Red River Delta (红河平原) was developed relatively early, ultimately possessing advantages in population, technology, and organization; consequently, over a span of 1,000 years, it doubled its national territory by expanding southward.

(People might assume, because Vietnam is identically governed by the Communist Party today, that since its independence during our nation's Five Dynasties period [五代时期], Vietnam wholly inherited China's **restoration-bureaucratic system** [复辟官僚制度]. However, according to my observation, until Western influence on Indochina became pronounced, Vietnam's degree of **feudalization** should not have been lower than that of the Tang Dynasty [唐代] in China, whether compared to the early Tang with its Fubing system [府兵制 / garrison militia system] or the mid-to-late Tang characterized by a proliferation of Fanzhen [藩镇 / regional military governors]. There was fundamentally no problem forming an organizational advantage over Champa [占婆] and the Khmer [高棉]).

The more backward Philippines (菲律宾) became a Catholic nation due to Spanish colonial activities, but Islam identically reached its southern islands. As for East Timor (东帝汶) and the regions in eastern Indonesia where primitive faiths still exist, they severely lacked influence. The contemporary religious landscape of **Southeast Asia** was forged in this exact manner.

The reason Mahayana Buddhism, having entered East Asia via the Silk Road, is still regarded today as synonymous with Northern Buddhism is simply that China did not embark upon a normal **feudalization** process. The **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家) successfully restored itself and has ruled for 14 centuries to the present day, and the concept of "China" *de facto* occupies the overwhelming majority of the population and territory in East Asia.

Under such circumstances, let alone a feudalized religion, even Mahayana Buddhism—capable of serving as the ideological pillar for a **classical empire**—could not escape successive anti-Buddhist campaigns (灭佛运动). The monastic organizations of all religions in our nation suffered devastating destruction.

Although Mahayana Buddhism can barely be termed China's most popular religious faith even today, it has long degenerated into a dilapidated state. It possesses zero theoretical innovation, lacks any respectable monastic order (僧团), and bears absolutely no significant social function.

The sole meaning of its continued existence, the singular reason the rulers consider it useful, is practically reduced to what Karl Marx (马克思) referred to as the "opium of the people" (“人民的鸦片”) in his *Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right* (《黑格尔法哲学批判》).

Although Japanese Buddhism (日本的佛教) belongs to Mahayana Buddhism (大乘佛教) due to the vectors of its dissemination, it underwent manifest changes during the **feudalization** (封建化) of the Japanese archipelago (日本列岛).

Distinct from the Mahayana Buddhism (*especially Esoteric Buddhism* [密宗]) of the Heian period (平安时代)—which was supported by the imperial family (皇室) and nobility (贵族), and relied on esoteric arts (法术) and complex rituals (仪式) for the spiritual protection of the state (镇护国家)—Buddhism during Japan's Chūsei (中世 / Middle Ages) underwent a monumental transformation.

Among these changes, the most conspicuous aspect was the End-of-Dharma ideology (末法思想) and the Pure Land ideology (净土思想). If one considers them alongside Christianity (基督教), one discovers something exceedingly fascinating. Buddhism maintains the theory of reincarnation (轮回论) consistent across Indian religions, which logically possesses a stark distinction from the eschatology / theory of judgment (审判论) held by Christianity and Islam (伊斯兰教). However, as Japan transitioned from a **classical society** (古典社会) to a **feudal society** (封建社会), the End-of-Dharma and Pure Land ideologies applied a potent patch to the original view of reincarnation, causing it to trend toward the Last Judgment (末世审判) to a certain extent.

Naturally, Japanese medieval Buddhism also upheld the concept of reincarnation, but it intensified prophecies regarding eschatological catastrophes, amplified the terror and severe punishments of hell (地狱), and emphasized the salvific function (救赎作用) of faith and adherence to Buddhist guidance. Medieval Buddhism provided people with explicit cultivation goals and simplified cultivation methods. It posited that through active moral judgments and choices in the present life (现世), people could reap different outcomes after death: either being reborn (往生) into the pure and



solemn Pure Land of the Buddha realm (佛国净土) to continue cultivation until attaining Buddhahood (成佛), or descending into the evil realms (恶道) to undergo perpetual reincarnation.

Medieval Buddhism prioritized practice and experiential understanding, reducing its reliance on scriptures. It emphasized "directly pointing to the human mind, seeing one's nature and attaining Buddhahood" (直指人心, 见性成佛); its cultivation methods became more operational for the common populace, and Esoteric Buddhism correspondingly declined. Consequently, monks were able to penetrate deeply into society to propagate the Dharma (佛法) to ordinary citizens. Buddhist ideologies were gradually embraced by all social strata, and Buddhism participated increasingly deeply in social life, serving to provide public services.

By the mid-to-late Muromachi period (室町时代中后期), powerful monastic organizations (僧团组织) already possessed the capacity to mobilize and organize the populace to launch massive uprisings, and even displaced local **feudal lords** (领主) to establish their own regimes. Although Japanese Buddhism remained formally classified as Mahayana Buddhism, the disparities had become colossal. For instance, one can clearly observe that Japanese Buddhism emphasized the concept of "living Bodhisattvas" (菩萨在世) far less than Chinese Buddhism (中国佛教) did. After all, having undergone the baptism of **feudal society**, the ideology of achieving salvation (救赎) through one's own faith and will had overwhelmed the concept of being saved by others through pious devotion.

These mutations occurring within Japanese medieval Buddhism demonstrate once again that certain fundamental postulates of Karl Marx (马克思) can genuinely be considered profound insights: **social being** (社会存在) determines **social consciousness** (社会意识) with such intense gravity. To the extent that, although Buddhism is a religion ostensibly vastly different from Christianity, as long as Japan's social structure approximated that of Western Europe (西欧), the religion (*or mainstream ideology*) prevalent in Japanese society would inevitably exhibit a tendency to evolve toward Western European **feudal religions** (封建宗教). This remained true even if the masters who founded the sects of Kamakura Buddhism (镰仓佛教) had never heard of God (上帝) and Jesus (耶稣), nor knew of Allah (真主) and Muhammad (穆罕默德).

Korean Buddhism (朝鲜佛教) was just as ill-fated as the peninsula (半岛) itself.

Goguryeo (高句丽), functioning as the easternmost terminus of the great migrations (民族大迁徙) during Late Antiquity (古典时代晚期) and the early **feudal period** (封建早期) (*here I refer to the timelines of "individual nations" rather than the standard European timeline, though at that time, the process of the great migrations across the Eurasian continent possessed chronological continuity*), was completely blocked by the Xianbei people (鲜卑人) from advancing into the Central Plains, compelling Goguryeo to exclusively expand southward into the Korean Peninsula. Because the Korean Peninsula was situated at the periphery of Chinese rule, it was far from being **feudalized** in that era, making it highly unlikely for **The Landlord-Bureaucrat Compromise** (地主-官僚妥协) to occur here.

Silla (新罗) and Baekje (百济) at the southern tip of the peninsula also ascended rapidly under external influence. Observation here is prone to certain issues. Although Goguryeo, Silla, and Baekje appeared to possess certain **feudal characteristics** (封建特征), I maintain that overall, the Three Kingdoms of Korea (朝鲜半岛三国) at that time had nowhere near developed into a genuine **feudal society**. These three nations should be analogous to Japan during the Asuka and Nara periods

(飞鸟奈良时期), fundamentally still belonging to the category of **early states** (早期国家). However, because China's sheer mass was overwhelmingly massive and excessively proximate, they suffered excessively potent influence. During the process of forcibly introducing the Chinese bureaucratic system (官僚制度), they augmented royal power (王权) and acquired a bureaucratic apparatus substantially stronger relative to their existing developmental stage.

If one assumes the Korean Peninsula is difficult to observe due to excessive interference from bordering China, a highly simple example can illustrate this point: Japan's Uji-Kabane system (氏姓制) (of the late Kofun period [古坟时代晚期]) was highly likely connected to the Bone-rank system (骨品制度) implemented by Silla, namely, the former emulated the latter. Furthermore, even after Silla unified the Three Kingdoms, aristocratic politics (贵族政治) continued to exert a massive influence on this regime; attempts to emulate China in establishing a formidable bureaucratic system ultimately failed.

In reality, to a large extent, from the fifth century right up to the thirteenth century, the historical trajectory of the Korean Peninsula was fundamentally synchronized with that of Japan, merely exhibiting differences in manifestation. The Three Kingdoms of Korea period and the Unified Silla period (统一新罗时期) were exactly like Japan's Asuka and Nara periods (*in fact, the Balhae regime [渤海国政权] in Northeast China [中国东北地区] could identically be added to this sequence*). They belonged to the stage where **early states** introduced the bureaucratic system from China to fortify centralized state power (中央集权). Foreign Buddhism was primarily utilized to consolidate royal power and provide spiritual protection for the state; this was indistinguishable from Japan, and Mahayana Buddhism was patently conducive to realizing this objective.

During the period when the Goryeo Dynasty (王氏高丽) ruled the Korean Peninsula (朝鲜半岛), the prosperous landscape of a **classical empire** (古典帝国) emerged. From the latter half of the 10th century to the early 12th century, the centralized bureaucratic system (中央集权官僚体制) of this nation operated stably.

Unfortunately, what the Goryeo people could learn at that time was China's **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制度). For instance, the imperial examination system (科举) was utilized in Goryeo to elevate individuals from various strata to consolidate despotic rule (专制统治). Simultaneously, Goryeo rulers began establishing and encouraging the construction of a school education system guided by Confucianism (儒学). Such an excessively potent bureaucratic system during the **classical period** would subsequently bring immense difficulties to this peninsula.

The Goryeo regime was militarily highly formidable; the size of its army could be considered absolutely astonishing relative to the sheer mass of the Korean Peninsula. Goryeo exhibited a potent posture militarily when confronting the Liao Dynasty (辽朝) and the Jin Dynasty (金朝). This formidable state power rendered the Goryeo people more confident in diplomacy. They affirmed themselves as the "Empire East of the Sea" (海东的帝国) and believed they ought to possess their own tributary sphere (朝贡圈) modeled after China. The massiveness of architecture during the Goryeo period identically reflected the confidence of this Empire East of the Sea.

This empire indeed possessed numerous commendable attributes in technological innovation. Goryeo celadon (高丽青瓷) is arguably world-renowned, the *Tripitaka Koreana* (《高丽大藏经》) was inscribed on the UNESCO Memory of the World Register, and movable metal type printing (金

属活字印刷术) was identically invented here. Although Goryeo Buddhism (高丽佛教) during this period could not possibly occupy a monopoly position due to the flourishing of Confucianism, it identically enjoyed a golden age during the **classical period** of the Korean Peninsula.

In the final years of Goryeo, **feudalization** (封建化) occurred nonetheless. However, because the Korean Peninsula excessively introduced China's **restoration-bureaucratic system** during its classical zenith—and did not, like Japan during the Heian period (平安时代), promptly abandon it upon discovering its incompatibility (*which was a phenomenal achievement; when Japan entered its genuine classical zenith during the Insei [院政] period, the Ritsuryo system [律令制] had de facto perished, and the identity among the samurai [武士] had already begun to develop*)—Korea's **feudalization** process was fraught with immense difficulties from the very inception.

Although the so-called Musin regime (武臣政权) of late Goryeo appeared formally somewhat similar to the Japanese shogunate (幕府), the Choe regime (崔氏政权) of Goryeo undeniably lacked the economic foundation and legitimacy to establish stable rule. I surmise that in essence, it was still a *warlord regime* from the period when the **classical empire** was about to disintegrate; however, because Goryeo itself was relatively small in scale, a single *warlord regime* was able to rule the entire country and could even pass down power hereditarily for several generations."

Buddhism, as the mainstream religion of Korea, responded to these mutations. Zen Master Jinul (知讷禅师) established the Jogye Order (曹溪宗) during the period of military rule. He attempted to construct a new sect with rigorous precepts to unify the various factions within Korean Buddhism, and he amplified perspectives unique to Zen Buddhism (禅宗)—such as sudden enlightenment (顿悟)—to enable commoners to comprehend and embrace Buddhism. At this juncture, Goryeo Buddhism indeed exhibited a tendency to transform toward a **feudal religion** (封建宗教), exactly like Japanese Buddhism.

The problem was that the Mongol (蒙古) invasions violently interrupted this. After being (indirectly) ruled by the Mongols for a century, the Goryeo regime did not usher in a renaissance; instead, it was replaced via a coup d'état by a general named Yi Seong-gye (李成桂), thereby establishing the Joseon Dynasty (朝鲜李朝).

The peculiarity of the Joseon regime lay in its achievement of a mutually beneficial win-win scenario between rulers by establishing a suzerain-vassal relationship (宗藩关系) with the Ming Dynasty (明朝) (*although stating it this way feels somewhat peculiar, anyone can ultimately discern that the Ming Dynasty was the suzerain, hence the word order remains unadjusted*). The Ming emperor manifested the majesty of the Celestial Empire's (天朝) monarch through the "loyal" vassal state of Joseon, while the King of Joseon executed his bureaucratic rule domestically relying on the strength and the investiture endorsement of the Ming Dynasty.

Before the establishment of the Joseon Dynasty, although Korea did not undergo a conspicuous phase of **classical empire** collapse and barbarian invasion, nor did a genuine **feudal regime** (封建政权) emerge across the entire peninsula, it is fundamentally acceptable to identically regard Joseon as a **restoration-bureaucratic state** (复辟官僚国家). The Joseon regime was indeed an excellent student of the Chinese empire; during its five centuries of rule, it fundamentally adhered to the policy of "Revering Confucianism and Suppressing Buddhism" ("崇儒抑佛"), subjecting Buddhists to severe suppression and even persecution.

Korean Buddhism, exactly like the nation of Korea itself, marched into a dark age, never again undergoing the **feudalization** metamorphosis like its Japanese counterparts.

As two nations that successfully emancipated themselves from China's direct control, Korea (朝鮮) and Vietnam (越南) nonetheless remained subjected to massive Chinese influence, particularly in adopting the Chinese-style bureaucratic system (官僚制度)—naturally, the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制度). Although the **restoration-bureaucratic system** learned by the students was ultimately not as terrifying as the master's, the religions in these two regions (*naturally, primarily Buddhism [佛教]*) were not reduced to a state of fundamental eradication. However, its prolonged stagnation in the morphology of the **classical period** (古典时期) was fundamentally incapable of satisfying the demands of societal development; after all, **classical society** (古典社会) had ceased to exist regardless.

When Europeans forcibly blew open the gates of various Asian nations with military might, the **bureaucratic states** (官僚国家) of Korea and Vietnam were defeated, and their ideological chaos and hollowness were rapidly exposed. Today in South Korea, Buddhism at best shares equal footing with Christianity (基督教); in reality, it is claimed that Christianity has become the largest religion in South Korea. Moreover, there are overwhelmingly numerous Christian denominations in South Korea, many belonging to house churches (家庭基督教) unmanaged by formal ecclesiastical structures. In Vietnam, although Buddhism (*predominantly Mahayana Buddhism [大乘佛教]*) remains the largest organized religion, Catholicism (天主教) identically occupies a paramount influence within society. Furthermore, Vietnam birthed a cohort of indigenous religions synthesizing the ideologies of multiple sects, such as Hòa Hảo (和好教) and Cao Đài (高台教).

If we juxtapose these two nations with Japan (日本)—which successfully navigated the entire **feudalization process** (封建化过程) and whose religious faith identically completed adaptive mutations—the differences are glaringly apparent. Although Japan suffered aggression from Western powers and was defeated as an aggressor in World War II, this nation has marched toward secularization (世俗化) since the modern era. Even among the demographic possessing religious faith, indigenous religious beliefs occupy a dominant position. If one further notices the exponential proliferation of mosques in western China since the Reform and Opening-up (改革开放), alongside the vigorous expansion of rural Christian churches in the Central Plains (中原地区), it is not difficult to realize that the historical religious policies of **restoration-bureaucratic states** exert a phenomenally peculiar impact upon the contemporary religious landscapes of these nations.

Mahayana Buddhism was transmitted into China, Korea, Japan, and Vietnam in the form of Exoteric Buddhism (显宗). Although Esoteric Buddhism (密宗 / Tantrism) inevitably propagated here later, it had already forfeited the possibility of generating colossal influence. China, Korea, and Vietnam generally adopted a disparaging and suppressive attitude toward Buddhism; regardless of whether it was Exoteric or Esoteric, any organized religion constituted a threat to the **bureaucratic state**. Japanese Buddhism, conversely, having undergone the baptism of the medieval feudal revolution, identically no longer required the labyrinthine rituals and mystical cultivation of Esoteric Buddhism.

Mahayana Buddhism had already been transmitted to the Qinghai-Tibet Plateau (青藏高原) as early as the Tibetan Empire (吐蕃帝国) period; however, the political chaos during the late Tibetan Empire

inflicted a devastating blow upon the development of Tibetan Buddhism (藏地佛教). Fortunately, at this juncture, the Pala Empire (波罗王朝) was still propping up the teetering classical system in northeastern India and continued to sponsor the comprehensively Tantrified Mahayana Buddhism. Chronologically, this granted Buddhism a second opportunity for transmission onto the Qinghai-Tibet Plateau. Ultimately, Mahayana Esoteric Buddhism discovered an environment conducive to its own development on the Qinghai-Tibet Plateau and, subsequently, the Mongolian Plateau (蒙古高原).

Although, formally speaking, the Qinghai-Tibet Plateau identically entered a feudal state following the collapse of the Tibetan Empire, the climate here was ultimately severe, rendering it immensely difficult for secular regimes to shoulder the heavy burden of administrative management independently. Under these conditions, Buddhist monasteries frequently functioned as massive **feudal lords** (封建领主). Religion and religious organizations were compelled to participate deeply in social governance, and regimes in the Tibet (西藏) region exhibited tendencies toward a theocracy (政教合一) to varying degrees. When Tibetan Buddhism itself needed to emerge in the guise of a ruler, the doctrines and **religious laws** (教法) of Esoteric Buddhism became phenomenally meaningful, while the concept of "Bodhisattvas saving the world" (菩萨救世) proved highly conducive to inducing ideological submission among the ruled.

During its developmental trajectory, Tibetan Buddhism concurrently preserved Mahayana Esoteric doctrines and managed to adapt to the demands of ruling a **feudal society** (封建社会) under exceptional environments. For instance, the so-called institution of reincarnate lamas (活佛转世制度) was precisely such an invention adopted to maintain the stability of power transitions. During the late Ming and Qing Dynasties, the Mongolian pastoral areas (蒙古牧区) identically developed—either actively or passively—a **feudal system** (封建制度) (*as mentioned previously*). Similar to the environment of the Tibetan regions, the Mongolian pastoral areas were identically harsh, possessing vast territories with sparse populations; administrative management and public services were fundamentally inseparable from religious organizations. Within the periphery of the Mongolian regions, the religion most adaptable to this circumstance was explicitly Tibetan Buddhism. Therefore, it is entirely unsurprising that the Mongols universally adhered to Tibetan Buddhism during the three centuries prior to Russian intervention, not to mention that the Qing rulers persistently and deliberately propelled this dynamic.

Now shifting our gaze to Theravada Buddhism (上座部佛教), although the region where Mahayana Buddhism (大乘佛教) is prevalent is vastly larger in scale than that of Theravada Buddhism, the legendary nature of the latter is not diminished in the slightest.

Because the transmitted historical documents from nations such as Sri Lanka (斯里兰卡), Myanmar (缅甸), Thailand (泰国), Laos (老挝), and Cambodia (柬埔寨) are significantly fewer relative to the nations of Northern Buddhism (北传佛教), it is exceedingly difficult for people to accurately know how today's Theravada Buddhism evolved from the Sthavira school during the period of Sectarian Buddhism (部派佛教). How did today's Theravada Buddhism and the original "Buddhism of the Sthaviras" evolve in terms of **religious doctrines** (教义) and **religious laws** (教法)? After all, it was fundamentally impossible for the Sthaviras to have already adapted to a **feudal society** (封建社会)—which did not yet exist at the time—during the BC era. Even if there are still documents scattered

across the world capable of revealing this, it is not something I can comprehend through the Internet from within China.

The cradle of Theravada Buddhism was Sri Lanka; initially, Ashoka (阿育王) dispatched his son to this region to propagate the Dharma. Interestingly, although Theravada Buddhism accompanied the entirety of Sri Lanka's history, Sri Lankan Buddhism did not remain utterly unchanged. I only happened to learn of this while playing a massive modification for Paradox's *Crusader Kings III* (《十字军之王3》) entitled "Regional Immersion and Cultural Enrichment" (区域沉浸和文化丰富).

The earliest Buddhist sect transmitted into Sri Lanka subsequently evolved into the Mahavihara (大寺派), a sect that persistently adhered to Theravada doctrines. During the first century BC, the King of Sri Lanka sponsored the construction of the Abhayagiri Vihāra (无畏山寺), which later became the center of the Abhayagiri (无畏山派). This Buddhist sect embraced the ascendant Mahayana doctrines as well as the later Tantric (密宗) doctrines; Abhayagiri Vihāra seemingly became a center for Mahayana Buddhism.

Later, a branch of the Abhayagiri sect established the Jetavana Vihāra (祇陀林寺), forming the Jetavanavihara (祇陀林派) in the fourth century. This sect identically propagated Mahayana Buddhism, though it appeared more strategic in its competition with the Mahavihara sect. Beginning in the third and fourth centuries AD, Sri Lankan rulers began intentionally favoring the Abhayagiri sect. After the Relic of the tooth of the Buddha (佛牙舍利) was brought to Sri Lanka in the fourth century, it was enshrined at the Abhayagiri Vihāra; over the subsequent centuries, this location served as Sri Lanka's primary academic center.

At the dawn of the second millennium AD, Sri Lanka faced increasingly severe military invasions from the direction of Southern India (南印度). The Chola Dynasty (朱罗王朝), devoutly adhering to Hinduism (印度教), clearly had no necessity for—nor would they welcome—a massive monastery propagating classical Buddhism. Once Sri Lanka expelled the invaders and restored its independence, the rulers immediately pivoted toward the Mahavihara sect, suppressing the Abhayagiri and Jetavanavihara sects. Mahayana Buddhism and Tantrism ultimately perished in Sri Lanka.

The shifting balance of power among Sri Lankan Buddhist sects is exceptionally intriguing. It is fundamentally impossible for people to determine from historical documents exactly when Sri Lanka approximated a **classical society** (古典社会), and when it began marching toward a **feudal society**. Yet, the saga of the rise and fall of these three Buddhist sects on an island of less than 70,000 square kilometers so vividly delineates the universal underlying laws of human societal development: transitioning from an **early state** (早期国家) into a **classical society**, and subsequently marching from a **classical society** toward a **feudal society**.

That Theravada Buddhism was able to secure a foothold on the Indochinese Peninsula (中南半岛) is inseparable from geographical conditions. After all, although Myanmar appears adjacent to India and Bengal, the overland transportation routes are truly excessively treacherous. Conversely, it was substantially easier to reach the Indochinese Peninsula via maritime routes from Southern India and Sri Lanka. Provided we tentatively concede that by the 11th century, Theravada Buddhism had fundamentally completed its transmutation into a **feudal religion** (封建宗教) in terms of doctrines and **religious laws**, then it is not surprising in the slightest that the Bamar (缅人) and the Tai peoples

(傣泰人) migrating southward from within Chinese territory selected Theravada Buddhism. This was the **feudal religion** they were most familiar with and found easiest to embrace.

The only thing that feels genuinely miraculous is Cambodia. This nation, functioning as the remnant of the Khmer Empire (高棉帝国), actually also selected Theravada Buddhism. However, this was precisely one of the correct choices the Cambodians made during the collapse of their **classical empire** (古典帝国); another correct choice was none other than abandoning Angkor (吴哥) and relocating the capital to Phnom Penh (金边).

The Khmer ruler Indravarman III (因陀罗跋摩三世) made the courageous decision to convert to Theravada Buddhism at a time when the empire was already tottering precariously under the offensives of the Thai people. As the ruler during the terminal phase of a **classical empire**, although it was inevitable to perceive a cataclysmic disaster, to remain unbeguiled by the glory that had already become a fleeting illusion, and to proactively embrace the religion of the enemy, was undeniably phenomenal. (Naturally, as the **feudalization** process of Khmer society itself unfolded, Theravada Buddhism also expanded within the empire; therefore, it cannot be entirely characterized as the "religion of barbarian enemies.") Later, when Emperor Minh Mạng (明命帝) of Vietnam invaded Laos and Cambodia, he witnessed the potency of Theravada Buddhism in organizing national resistance. Consequently, he harbored a visceral hatred for Theravada Buddhism, wishing to eradicate it entirely from the lands conquered by the Vietnamese.

Indravarman III indeed succeeded. Although the disintegration of the **classical empire** was inevitable (*and it arguably ought to have disintegrated*), the Cambodians at least preserved the core territory of the Khmer Empire, and the paternal ancestors of the current Cambodian royal family can be traced back furthest precisely to this courageous monarch. I maintain that the Khmer Empire's performance during its curtain call was superior to that of Byzantium (拜占庭); at the very least, Angkor Wat (吴哥窟) remains a World Heritage site and tourist destination belonging to Cambodia today.

Finally, let us briefly examine the Southwest China region wedged between two Buddhist worlds—more precisely, the Southwest China region during the rule of the Nanzhao (南诏) and Dali (大理) regimes.

Buddhism during the Nanzhao and Dali periods is colloquially referred to in China as Dian Esoteric Buddhism (滇密), academically known as Azhaliism (阿吒力教). Formally, this is undoubtedly a variant of Esoteric Buddhism (密宗), as it heavily promoted esoteric cultivation and the taking of shortcuts (捷径). However, the "esoteric" aspect of Dian Esoteric Buddhism was not characterized by scholastic, complex mystical rituals; rather, it more closely approximated a syncretism of various primitive faiths (原始信仰的杂糅), while concurrently being astonishingly lax regarding precepts (戒律).

The fact that this religion could flourish in both the **classical empire** (古典帝国) of Nanzhao and the **feudal regime** (封建政权) of Dali reflects the complex political landscape of the mountainous regions of Southwest China: even if a **classical state** (古典国家) or **feudal state** (封建国家) could be established relying on the limited plains (*the so-called "Bazi" [坝子]*) nestled among towering mountains, the diverse and highly primitive tribes in the surrounding mountainous areas

fundamentally could not be eradicated. Only industrial civilization (工业文明) is capable of achieving this.

In reality, if we recall the previously mentioned situation where the Chancellor family, the Gao clan (相国家族高氏), monopolized power during the Dali period, it is not difficult to discern that even though the Dali regime was originally established by Duan Siping (段思平) relying on the armed forces of various eastern tribal chieftains, it was still necessary to defend against these "savages" (野人) in the east after Dali was established. Regardless of whether the rulers of Nanzhao or Dali desired it, to avoid remaining in a perpetual state of hostility with these fundamentally ineradicable tribes, they were structurally compelled to make ideological compromises. Dian Esoteric Buddhism was precisely such a religion. Naturally, we must not forget that when Nanzhao and Dali confronted the colossal behemoth that was the Chinese empire (中华帝国), they indeed possessed a tangible necessity to maintain their independence through a unique religious culture; Dian Esoteric Buddhism identically assumed this function.

If *feudal society* (封建社会) in Southwest China had been able to progress further, we would naturally have reason to believe that Buddhism here would gradually have evolved the characteristics of a *feudal religion* (封建宗教), but history clearly did not grant Yunnan (云南) this opportunity.

Thus, we have completed a brief, holistic examination of the history of Buddhism's propagation. By this point, readers can ostensibly realize that although Karl Marx (马克思) committed numerous errors, the postulate that *social being* (社会存在) determines *social consciousness* (社会意识) is genuinely a profound insight, even if it contained elements of guesswork during his era.

If future scholars can deeply research the commonalities between *religious doctrines* (宗教教义), *religious laws* (宗教教法), and the social structures of the regions where they flourish, it might highly likely be possible to realize such a "program": we would merely need to input the limited state parameters of a society to determine exactly what minimal characteristics the prevalent religion or ideology of that society ought to possess.

We can acknowledge this with complex emotions. Although currently it appears that individual free will still exists, for society as a whole, the manifestation of *social consciousness* genuinely lacks freedom. When a religion is capable of satisfying the demands generated by the extant developmental state of a society, it effectively occupies the position of *social consciousness*. Unless another religion emerges that is more suitable and capable of replacing it, it is exceedingly difficult to alter, even through violent suppression. When the society itself undergoes mutations, the religion originally prevalent in that society must either adapt to these changes, or be eliminated by a religion—emerging from parts unknown—capable of adapting to the new circumstances.

What we observe is precisely this. Viewed from the perspective of the societal whole, what determines where a religion can develop is nothing more than two points: adaptation and the first-mover advantage. Concurrently, a brief review of the history of Buddhism can also assist us in more profoundly comprehending the characteristics and evolution of social ideologies during the *classical period* (古典时期) and the *feudal period* (封建时期).



People might criticize me for extensively examining religions currently prevalent in Asia while failing to carefully investigate the circumstances of Christianity (基督教); I will explain why I adopted this approach.

The first reason, naturally, is because attempting to understand Christianity in China—not merely a rough outline, but a detailed understanding of its developmental process and the disparities among various denominations—is truly far too difficult. On March 8, 2025, while waiting to enter the examination hall for the Teacher Qualification Certificate Examination at Chang'an No. 3 Middle School in Xi'an (西安市长安区第三中学), I strolled around this small campus. I was profoundly astonished to discover that the content on the school's cultural display board regarding the *Nestorian Stele* (《大秦景教流行中国碑》) from the Stele Forest in Xi'an (西安碑林) actually, and rather farcically, utilized Pinyin (拼音) censorship.

It referred to Christianity as the "JD-religion" (JD 教) and missionaries as "CJ-ers" (CJ 士); this derived from extracting the first letters of the Hanyu Pinyin for the four characters "Ji Du" (基督 / Christ) and "Chuan Jiao" (传教 / missionary). This left me fundamentally speechless. The Church of the East (东方基督教会) to which Nestorianism (景教) belonged has long since lost any influence today due to perennial subjugation under Muslim rule; this inexplicable paranoia is truly absurd.

Yet our nation's religious policy is precisely thus. Even though the *Nestorian Stele* is explicitly included as teaching content in middle school textbooks, absolutely no one is willing to violate taboos in public spaces and invite any unnecessary trouble. If readers can deeply perceive this reality, they will naturally understand why it is simply impossible for me to conduct an investigation into Christianity.

The second reason is that I possess absolute confidence in the research caliber of Western scholars regarding Christianity. Setting aside academic proficiency, Western scholars—purely due to their living environment—are inherently vastly more familiar with Christianity than an Easterner. Although I face difficulties in searching for and reading materials currently, I believe that articles and treatises introducing the developmental history of Christianity and its various denominations in detail must have been published long ago, making it entirely unnecessary to replicate the work.

## 27，以佛教为例说明封建化过程中的社会思想变化

之前已经分散地说明了封建化对于社会意识造成的冲击以及对于宗教传播所形成的影响，在这里我们以佛教历史上传播的地区为考察范围，以佛教自身以及其与其他宗教相竞争的历史中集中说明这一点。人类历史上佛教曾经盛行的地区的范围包括南亚，东亚，东南亚以及中亚的一部分，这个区域现在仍然生活着全世界半数的人口，在古代占有的比例更大，因此以佛教为主线考察封建思想的流变是比较有代表性的。

佛教与耆那教一样，诞生在大扩张时代的晚期，同时也是古典时代的形成期。虽然这两种宗教的教义显然具有其创始人和重要追随者强烈的个性特点，但是佛教和耆那教的流行的确是其贴合社会发展要求的产物。例如对于婆罗门教严格的种姓制度的反对，对于复杂且耗资巨大的祭祀的批评，强调个人努力的作用（通过修行得到解脱，当然是有条件的自由意志），非暴力的思想，对商业伦理的适应（提倡诚实和节俭），僧团能够为商业社群提供一定的帮助等等。这些新的宗教观念反映了大扩张以来社会意识的变化，并且有利于古典社会的构建，因此得到了社会许多阶层的广泛欢迎。当然也不乏统治者的青睐，毕竟在古典帝国形成的过程中，新崛起的君主肯定对于婆罗门祭司的态度不会太友好，他们不仅自己就

很可能出身于低种姓群体，而且为了增强专制权力也有必要利用对于种姓制度有所批判的新宗教。这一点是非常决定性的，因为婆罗门教或印度教完全可以变成有助于神化专制君主的形式，例如在高棉帝国人们明显看到了这种适应。但是无论如何婆罗门教和印度教都难以否认自身教义中的种姓观念以及婆罗门祭司的作用，这对于试图增加专制权力的君主而言终究是不如大乘佛教方便。

在古典印度的形成时期，印度列国的统治者们对反对婆罗门教的沙门思潮表现出了强烈的兴趣和支持。佛教能够在众多沙门思潮中脱颖而出，与佛教本身的一些教义和教法是分不开的。例如接受施舍和不婚，这对统治者显然意味着僧伽团体是一个相对容易控制的宗教团体。

当然，释迦牟尼传播自己所觉悟的智慧时大概率也不是以创造一个宗教组织为目的，早期的佛教更像是一种哲学流派，就像古希腊的各种哲学派别一样。因此这种个人感悟式的意识形态虽然因为释迦牟尼本身也生在那个年代不可避免地具有符合社会发展的认识存在，但是究竟不是一种专门支撑古典社会的宗教思想。释迦牟尼时期所确定的基本思想观念和僧团组织使得佛教注定要向一个宗教转化，毕竟它已经具备了良好的基础，并且在社会上取得了一席之地。在释迦牟尼去世之后，佛教很快就分裂成了各种派别，而在社会现实不断地筛选过程中，一种自称为“大乘佛教”的佛教派别在古典印度崛起了。

今天的中国佛教依然以大乘佛教为主，大乘佛教把与自己相对立的佛教派别称为“小乘佛教”，这显然是一种带有贬义的说法。小乘佛教的信徒一般认为自己属于“上座部佛教”，在中国，人们因为上座部佛教所流行的区域在南而称其为南传佛教。佛教的派别跟其他宗教的派别并没有什么区别，人人都试图宣称自己是释迦牟尼时期就存在的真正的佛法，具体怎么样现在也很难知晓。不过有意思的是，因为东亚地区和东南亚地区的历史发展差异，我们可以从今天仍然存在的大乘佛教和上座部佛教的教义和教法中明显看出这两种意识形态的核心区别不在于他们的哲学观点有多少差异，而在于他们适应了不同阶段的社会现实：大乘佛教是古典国家的国家宗教，上座部佛教是封建社会的封建宗教。接下来我们看看这两种佛教的差异何在，其实只需要列举出核心的区别自然就一目了然了。

上座部佛教修行以阿罗汉（Arhat）为目标，追求个人的涅槃；大乘佛教修行以菩萨（Bodhisattva）为目标，追求让所有众生都达到涅槃。上座部佛教更加强调佛陀作为导师的一面；大乘佛教强调佛陀的神性。上座部佛教强调通过自身的努力，遵循佛陀的教导修行达到阿罗汉；大乘佛教强调利他，不但要自行解脱，还要帮助一切众生解脱。上座部佛教的仪式相对简单，强调个人修行和对佛陀的敬仰；大乘佛教的仪式相对复杂，包括诵经、供养、法会等。上座部佛教更加强调出家人的修行和解脱，僧团组织严密并且深入民间；大乘佛教认为居家的信徒也可以修行到较高境界，僧团相对不那么严密并且与民间的联系较浅。上座部佛教在释经上更倾向于字面解释，而大乘佛教在解释经文上更加灵活。上座部佛教并不喜欢一些修行的方便法门，强调严格按照戒律；而大乘佛教允许使用各种方便的法门引导不同根基的众生修行。

其实我们这么一列举，已经看到这里的读者自然就明白为什么说大乘佛教是一种古典时期的宗教，而上座部佛教是一种封建宗教了。但是对于在所谓共产国家以外的，特别是在欧美还有日本这样的发达的民主国家的人来说，他们很难理解大乘佛教中菩萨“普度众生”这个思想的妙处。不明所以的人很容易认为这是一种崇高的道德品质，表现了一种强烈的自我牺牲精神。但我想说的是，所谓的菩萨普度众生在各种意义上与 20 世纪的独裁者们强调自己的卓越领导能够挽救民族属于同一种性质。当大乘佛教的理论在认可一个人可以修成菩萨来普度众生的时候，他的确又没办法否认这个人在现实中的形态上与人有什么差别。可是我们一旦把认为他是德行很高的“菩萨”，认为一小部分人具有帮助绝大多数人解脱的超人能力，那么在事实上就承认了人与人之间的巨大的不对等性。这就是所谓“我能解放你”这句话的隐含意义，这不仅是表达“我”有一种道德上的优越性，而且隐含了“我”在权力上的优势地位。实际上如果人们了解东亚笃信佛教或者利用佛教的专制君主的所作所为，就完全不会忽视这一点，这些统治者

往往就是以“菩萨”的身份参与宗教活动的。一直到中国的最后一个帝制政权也就是清朝，皇帝在面临藏地和蒙古这样笃信藏传佛教的地区时，仍然被视为文殊菩萨的化身。我们完全有理由认为，正是这种赋予专制君主神性和统治合法性的思想，构成了古典社会中大乘佛教广受（统治者）支持的基础。

因此在公元一世纪到七世纪，大乘佛教一跃而起成为佛教的主流，这正是南亚地区古典社会的辉煌年代。第一个对大乘佛教的发展起到巨大推动作用的是贵霜帝国，一个依赖国际贸易的古典帝国，佛教本身对于商业和城市文明的支持就已经十分有力。而大乘佛教中菩萨普度众生的观点对于统治者个人提升形象和权威实在是太无法抗拒了，无怪乎一代雄主迦腻色伽一世（Kanishka）被佛教视为最为伟大的君王之一。贵霜帝国对于大乘佛教最大的贡献在于雕塑艺术（这样说似乎有些奇怪，毕竟大乘佛教自身很可能就是在贵霜帝国支持下形成的），无论是统治者还是已经被视为神灵的诸佛都可以通过巨大的塑像来显示其无上的威势。在笈多王朝统治时期，统治者支持修建并一直赞助那烂陀寺，该寺庙后来成为大乘佛教庞大的学术中心。这一时期的大乘佛教发展出了极为复杂的哲学，其思辨性即使到今天也足以令世人叹为观止，当玄奘法师西行至此时，他希望学到的就是这样一种杰出的思想。人们不应忘记古典时代作为人类历史进程的一部分，反映其时代特征的思想必然具有复杂性，大乘佛教同样不可能只是一个为君主专制站台的意识形态，可取之处也是很多的。

从公元六世纪开始，北印度的古典社会开始衰退，按理来说此时大乘佛教正在失去其在起源地生存的基础。但是戏剧性的是，北印度的封建化进程虽然已经蓬勃发展起来，但是孟加拉地区却并没有。今天的整个孟加拉地区（包括孟加拉国和西孟加拉邦）生活着超过两亿五千万人口，但是在地理上看这里毕竟是印度次大陆的东北角，开发的时间比较晚，特别是沼泽密布河流纵横的现在孟加拉国地区。这种时间差最早可以通过北印度地区陶器文化在各地出现的时间被观察到，一言以蔽之，孟加拉国社会的历史进程从起步阶段就要晚于恒河流域大部分地区。在北印度的古典社会走向衰落的时候，崛起在孟加拉地区的波罗王朝（pala）却正在进入古典帝国的鼎盛时期。孟加拉国本身的农业条件绝不算差，而早期封建政权相对于古典帝国又不占有优势，波罗王朝得以扩张为一个大帝，特别是它征服了佛教的中心地区，原先的摩揭陀国。波罗王朝自然会继续支持大乘佛教这个已经高度适应古典时代的国家宗教，但是印度整体的封建化进程又无法阻挡，因此大乘佛教在波罗王朝统治时期发生了重要的变化，即密宗化。

之前我们说到古典社会衰退时期统治者往往会想尽办法增强其专制性权力来弥补社会性权力不可避免地丧失，因此寻求神秘主义作为神化自己的一个手段是非常正常的。站在统治者的需求来说，这的确是密宗开始占据大乘佛教主流的一个原因，毕竟大型寺院需要国家赞助，赞助者的需求必定会起到引导作用。况且当自身的教义和教法越来越不符合时代发展的要求时，宗教少有能寄希望的力量也就是意图利用自己的君主了，这种抱团取暖在当时符合双方利益。然而即使站在大乘佛教自身的角度来说，密宗化同样不可避免。作为在古典时期形成并发展的宗教，前期的大乘佛教已经演变出了适应古典社会的特征，例如理性主义，思想上百花齐放，重视思辨等等。在古典印度，大规模的宗教辩论是非常常见的，统治者即使的确青睐大乘佛教，也不可能独尊大乘佛教，因为古典帝国的基石就在于派系平衡。大乘佛教为了在竞争中取得优势，他就不得不发展出庞大的，集中的学术中心用来强化逻辑和辩论的训练，僧团组织也十分复杂。

可是到了波罗王朝崛起的时候，虽然孟加拉国的社会存在可以支撑这个古典帝国，但是印度其他地方特别是北印度毕竟封建化了。这就导致大乘佛教的竞争者们开始自发向封建宗教演变，尤其是在印度次大陆这个地方历史悠久的本土宗教，婆罗门教基本完成了向印度教的转变。封建化宗教将注意力大量投入在社会基层，主神崇拜确立，朝圣制度发展，吸纳地方神灵（往往是地方的女神作为印度教主神的妻子形象出现，这符合了封建时期民族意识出现的需求，尤其是在南印度），印度教寺庙开始承担封建社会中协助经济流通的作用。除了波罗王朝的领土，适应了封建化形势的印度教几乎在次大陆全境击退了佛

教。这不是说印度教教士放弃了跟佛教僧侣的辩论，可时代确实已经变了，印度教当然还需要通过辩论来证明自己正确，不过这已经不是主要的任务。对于大乘佛教来说，它现在空有那烂陀寺这样庞大的学术机构，但是“拔剑四顾心茫然”，游戏规则已经不同。宗教的组织体制发展了几个世纪就算不再适合时代发展也有它的惯性，到了公元后第一个千年的尾声，哪怕波罗王朝还维持着古典帝国的样貌，然而在一个日益封建化的时代，像那烂陀寺，超戒寺和飞行寺这样大而复杂的学术机构应该寻求怎样的合理性以维持下去？

密宗给出了在当时看来比较合理的回答。密宗自身首先就吸纳了一些封建宗教的意识，它比任何教派都更加强调修行中方便法门（即修行的“捷径”）的运用，很大程度上突破了戒律甚至利用世俗欲望进行修行。但是与封建宗教显著区别的是，密宗强调对于这些修行捷径的“控制”，它制定了一套极其繁琐的神秘仪式以及耗资巨大的供养手段，这就使得普通人虽然还能瞻仰一下佛陀的思想，但是想获得极高的修行境界基本不太可能。密宗强化了上师（Guru）的地位，强调对上师的绝对服从和虔诚，在缺少其指导的情况下密法修行几乎不可能成功。既然修行之路具有终南捷径，但是这样的捷径在没有人引导的情况下又不可能走得通，即使有人引导，也不得不投入大量的精力甚至是财富去弄清楚那些神秘咒语并完成复杂的宗教仪轨。那么在古典时代所形成的大乘佛教的大型学术中心自然就有了继续存在的意义，而统治者也从这种意识形态转变中获得了自身精神和政治需求的满足，因为只有具有高社会地位的人才有可能完成仪式和供养，这无疑增强了统治者身份上的优越性。

波罗王朝的兴盛不可能永远持续下去，公元 1000 年之后，即使是孟加拉的古典社会也在走向结束。在突厥穆斯林入侵的前夜，印度教政权重新在孟加拉国得势，但是到了 13 世纪，伊斯兰征服者抵达了这里。因为孟加拉地区历史起步得比较晚，在伊斯兰教政权征服这里时，孟加拉国当地的封建化进程刚刚起步，而伊斯兰教又是一个高度契合早期封建社会的宗教。因此在孟加拉国，伊斯兰教可以在几个世纪的统治中渐渐得到来自广大人民的拥护，并且被视为在印度教的汪洋大海中维护孟加拉国自身独立性的一种手段。在中国人民经常有这么一种偏见，即伊斯兰教是“沙漠中的宗教”，它最适合在干旱和半干旱地区传播。但是孟加拉和海岛东南亚的历史显然否定了这一点，气候类型和地貌类型不会直接决定伊斯兰教能在哪里扎根而不能在哪里扎根，真正起决定性作用的始终是当地的社会历史进程。

今天以印度为界，人们发现所谓的北传佛教基本是大乘佛教，而南传佛教基本是上座部佛教，这种现象不是偶然的。在大乘佛教兴起的时候，整个欧亚大陆仍然被几个虽然所处阶段有所差异，但是都可以归类为古典帝国的强大政权统治，而贸易和国际交流主要还是通过陆上的丝绸之路进行。当封建化已经席卷欧亚大陆的大部分地区，国际贸易的动脉转移到了地中海—印度洋—西太平洋的海上丝绸之路上。即使如此，最先在东南亚（和婆罗门教一起）取得胜利的仍然不是封建的上座部佛教，依然是大乘佛教。对于柬埔寨，苏门答腊和爪哇这些地区而言，各项条件不足以使其直接从早期国家进入封建社会，就算国际贸易的主干道途经东南亚，但是就绝对距离而言这里离印度和中国还是太远了。从公元 1000 年到欧洲人抵达的五个世纪间，中南半岛和海岛东南亚的古典社会（虽然后者比较原始）正在瓦解，上座部佛教得到了来自北方“蛮族”的青睐，最终取得了除越南外中南半岛的统治权，伊斯兰教随着商业传播被南岛各民族所接纳最终取得了海岛东南亚的统治权。越南虽然保留了来自中国的部分官僚制度，在历史上以大乘佛教为主要宗教（我不把儒家思想视为一种宗教）。但是从中国独立以来很长时间内封建化程度并不低，红河平原开发较早，在人口技术和组织上毕竟占有优势，因此在 1000 年的时间里向南方将国土扩张了一倍。（人们可能因为今天越南也是共产党执政而认为越南自我国五代时期独立以来全盘继承了中国的复辟官僚制度，但据我观察直到西方对印度支那的影响变得显著之前，越南的封建化程度应当不低于中国唐代，无论是存在府兵制的初唐还是藩镇林立的中晚唐，在组织能力上对占婆和高棉形成优势是没问题的）更加落后的菲律宾因为西班牙的殖民活动成为天主教国家，但是伊斯兰教同样抵达了南

部岛屿。至于东帝汶以及印度尼西亚东部仍然存在原始信仰的地区太缺少影响力。东南亚现今的宗教格局就是这样形成的。

大乘佛教随着丝绸之路进入东亚之后之所以至今仍被视为北传佛教的代名词，原因无非是中国没有正常走上封建化进程，官僚国家成功复辟并且统治了14个世纪至今，而“中国”这个概念事实上就占据了东亚人口和土地上的绝大多数。在这种情况下不要说封建化的宗教，即使是能够作为古典帝国信仰支柱的大乘佛教都逃不了一次又一次灭佛运动，我国各种宗教的教团组织都受到了毁灭性的破坏。大乘佛教虽然即使在今天也可以勉强称作中国最流行的宗教信仰，但是早就衰微得不成样子，没有什么理论上的创新，没有像样的僧团，不承担任何重要的社会功能。它能存在的唯一意义，统治者认为它是有用的唯一原因，几乎就剩下了马克思所说的作为“人民的鸦片”（《黑格尔法哲学批判》）。

日本的佛教虽然因为传播的原因属于大乘佛教，但是在日本列岛封建化的过程中发生了明显的变化。不同于平安时代受皇室和贵族支持的，寄希望于法术和复杂仪式镇护国家的大乘佛教（尤其是密宗），日本中世的佛教发生了巨大变化。其中最引人注目的一点就是末法思想和净土思想，如果人们将其与基督教放到一起考虑就会发现极其有意思的地方。佛教持有印度宗教一贯的轮回论观点，按理来说其与基督教和伊斯兰教所持有的审判论观点具有明显区别。但是当日本从古典社会向封建社会过渡的时候，末世和净土思想为原有的轮回观点打上了一个有力的补丁，使之在某种程度上有向末世审判靠拢的趋势。日本中世的佛教当然也秉持轮回的观点，但是它加强了对末世灾难的预言，强化了地狱的恐怖和严厉惩罚，并且强调了信仰并遵循佛教指引的救赎作用。中世佛教为人们提供了一个明确的修行目标并且简化了修行方法，认为人们能够通过现世的，主动的道德判断和选择在死后收获不同的结局，或者往生到清净庄严的佛国净土继续修行直到成佛，或者堕入恶道不断轮回。中世佛教重视实践和体验，对于经典的依赖程度降低，强调直指人心，见性成佛，修行方式对于平民百姓也更有操作性，密宗相对地衰落了。因此僧侣得以深入社会向普通民众传播佛法，佛教的思想逐渐被社会各个阶层所接纳，佛教越来越深度地参与到了社会生活中，起到了提供公共服务的作用。在室町时代中后期，强大的僧团组织已经具有发动组合组织民众进行大规模起义的能力，甚至取代当地领主建立了自己的政权。尽管日本的佛教仍然在形式上被归为大乘佛教，但是差别已经变得巨大，例如人们可以明显看到日本佛教对于“菩萨在世”这个概念远没有中国佛教这么强调。毕竟经过封建社会的洗礼，凭借自身信仰和意志实现救赎的思想已经压倒了通过虔诚奉献被人拯救的观念。日本中世佛教发生的这些变化再次说明马克思的一些基本观点确实可以算得上是真知灼见，社会存在如此强烈地决定了社会意识。以至于佛教明明是一个看起来跟基督教差别非常大的宗教，但是只要日本的社会结构与西欧相接近，那么日本社会所流行的宗教（或者说主流意识形态）就必然存在向西欧封建宗教进行演化的趋势。哪怕镰仓佛教那些开宗立派的大师们既没有听过上帝和耶稣，也不知道真主和穆罕默德。

朝鲜佛教就跟这个半岛一样命途多舛。高句丽作为古典时代晚期和封建早期（这里我指的是“各国的”时间表，并非欧洲标准的时间表，但是在当时看来欧亚大陆上的民族大迁徙进程具有时间上的连贯性）民族大迁徙的最东端，因为进入中原的道路被鲜卑人完全阻断，所以高句丽被迫只能南进朝鲜半岛。朝鲜半岛因其处于中国统治的边缘，故而在当年远未封建化，这里不太可能发生地主—官僚妥协。半岛南端的新罗和百济也在外界影响下迅速崛起。此处的观察容易出现一定问题，虽然说高句丽、新罗、百济看起来具有一些封建特征，但是总的来说我认为当时朝鲜半岛三国还远远没有发展到真正的封建社会。这三个国家应该和飞鸟奈良时期的日本相似，在本质上尚且属于早期国家，但是因为中国的体量过大，离得过近因此受到了过强的影响，在强行引入中国官僚制度的过程中增强了王权并且获得了相对现有发展阶段强很多的官僚体系。如果人们认为朝鲜半岛因为与中国接壤受到干扰过大而不好观察，有一个非常简单的事例可以说明这一点，那就是日本的氏姓制（古坟时代晚期）很有可能就与新罗实施的骨品制

度有联系，即前者模仿自后者。而且直到新罗统一三国之后，贵族政治仍然对于这个政权造成了很大影响，试图仿照中国建立强大官僚制度的尝试最终没有成功。实际上在很大程度上说，从五世纪一直到十三世纪为止，朝鲜半岛的历史进程跟日本基本是同步的，只是在表现上存在区别。朝鲜三国时期和统一新罗时期就如同飞鸟，奈良时代的日本一样（实际上，这个序列里还可以加上中国东北地区的渤海国政权），属于早期国家从中国引入官僚制度加强中央集权的阶段，外来的佛教主要被用于巩固王权和镇护国家，这一点跟日本没有区别，大乘佛教显然有利于实现这一点。

在王氏高丽时期统治朝鲜半岛时，古典帝国的繁盛局面出现了。从十世纪后半叶到十二世纪初，这个国家的中央集权官僚体制稳定运转。但是不幸的是，高丽人当时能学到的是中国的复辟官僚制度，例如科举在高丽被用于提拔不同阶层的人用来巩固专制统治，同时高丽统治者开始创办以及鼓励建设以儒学为指导思想的学校教育体系，这种在古典时代过强的官僚制度日后将为这个半岛带来极大的困难。高丽政权在军事上非常强大，军队数量相对于朝鲜半岛的体量来说完全可以算得上惊人了，高丽在军事上对抗辽朝和金朝时展现出了有力的姿态。这种强大的国家权力使得高丽人在外交上更为自信，他们确认自己是“海东的帝国”，并且应当仿照中国拥有自己的朝贡圈。高丽时期建筑的庞大也能体现出这个海东帝国的自信。这个帝国在技术创新上确实有很多可取之处，高丽青瓷可以说世界闻名，《高丽大藏经》被列入联合国教科文组织世界记忆国际名录，金属活字印刷术也在这里被发明。这一时期的高丽佛教虽然因为儒学的兴盛不可能占据独尊的地位，但是同样在朝鲜半岛的古典时代，享有了一段黄金时期。

在高丽末年，封建化还是发生了。不过由于朝鲜半岛在古典时期的鼎盛年代过多引入了中国复辟官僚体制，而没有像平安时代的日本一样发现无法适应就早早放弃（这是一件非常伟大的事情，当日本在院政时期进入真正的古典盛期，律令制事实上已经消亡了，而武士之间的认同也已经开始发展）朝鲜的封建进程一开始就困难重重。高丽晚期所谓武臣政权虽然在形式上看起来与日本幕府有一定相似性，但是高丽崔氏政权的确缺乏建立稳定统治的经济基础和合法性。我认为实质上它仍然是一个古典帝国行将解体的时期的军阀政权，但是因为高丽本身体量较小，因此单一军阀政权就能够统治全国，甚至能够世袭传递权力数代人。佛教作为朝鲜的主流宗教对于变化做出了回应，知讷禅师在武人掌权的时期创建了曹溪宗，他试图建立一个具有严明戒律的新教派以统一朝鲜佛教中的各个派别，并且发扬禅宗特有的观点（例如顿悟）使得普通百姓能够了解并接受佛教。这个时候，高丽佛教的确有和日本佛教一样像一种封建宗教转变的趋势。问题在于蒙古人的入侵打断了这一点。在被蒙古（间接）统治了一个世纪之后，高丽政权并没有迎来复兴反而被一位叫李成桂的将军通过政变取代了，朝鲜李朝因此得以建立。

李朝政权的特殊之处在于其通过与明朝建立宗藩关系（虽然这样说比较奇怪，但是毕竟谁都能看出来明朝是宗主国，因此不做语序调整）达到了一种统治者之间的共赢：明朝皇帝通过朝鲜国这个“忠诚”藩属地来彰显天朝君主的威严，而朝鲜国王则凭借明朝的实力和册封背书在国内执行其官僚统治。朝鲜李朝建立前朝鲜虽然没有经过一个明显的古典帝国崩溃和蛮族入侵阶段，整个半岛也没有出现过真正的封建政权，但是把李朝也视为一个复辟官僚国家并无不可。李朝政权的确是中华帝国的好学生，在其统治的五个世纪中基本坚持了“崇儒抑佛”的政策，佛教徒受到严厉打压甚至迫害。朝鲜佛教就和朝鲜这个国家一样走向了黑暗年代，再也没有像日本的同行一样发生封建化的蜕变。

朝鲜和越南作为两个虽说成功脱离中国直接控制，但是又受到中国巨大影响，尤其是采用中国式的官僚制度（当然是复辟时期的官僚制度）。虽说作为学生学到的复辟官僚制度毕竟没有师傅的可怕，这两个地方的宗教（当然主要是佛教）没有处于一种被基本消灭的状态。但它长期停留在古典时期的形态，其实根本无法满足社会发展的需要，毕竟古典社会无论如何已经不存在了。当欧洲人用武力打开亚洲各国国门之后，朝鲜和越南的官僚国家被击败，意识形态上的混乱和空洞很快就显现出来。今天在韩国佛教充其量只能与基督教平分秋色，实际上据称基督教已经成为韩国最大的宗教，而且韩国基督教派别非常

多，很多属于不受教会管理的家庭基督教。在越南虽然佛教（主体是大乘佛教）仍然是最大的有组织宗教，不过天主教也在社会中占有重要的影响力，而且越南诞生了一批融合几个教派思想的本土宗教，比如和好教和高台教。如果我们把这两个国家与正常走完封建化过程并且宗教信仰也完成了适应性变化的日本相比就很容易不同了，日本虽然遭到过西方列强的侵略，并且在第二次世界大战中作为侵略者被击败，但是这个国家在近现代以来是走向世俗化的，即使从具有宗教信仰的人群中看，本土宗教信仰也占据了统治地位。如果人们再注意到改革开放以来中国西部地区清真寺数目的激增，以及中原地区农村基督教会的蓬勃发展，就不难意识到复辟官僚国家在历史上的宗教政策会对这些国家现如今的宗教形势造成非常特殊的影响。

大乘佛教在中国、朝鲜、日本和越南是以显宗的形式传入的，虽然后来密宗不可避免地也会传播到这里，但是已经丧失了产生巨大影响的可能性。中国、朝鲜和越南总体上对佛教采取了一种贬抑的态度，不分什么显宗密宗，只要有组织的宗教就是官僚国家的一种威胁。而日本佛教经历了中世封建革命的洗礼同样也不再需要密宗的复杂仪轨和神秘修行。大乘佛教早已在吐蕃帝国时期就传入了青藏高原，然而吐蕃帝国晚期的政治混乱对于藏地佛教发展打击巨大。所幸这个时候的波罗王朝还在印度东北部支撑着摇摇欲坠的古典体制，并且继续资助已经全面密宗化的大乘佛教，这在时间上给予了佛教在青藏高原第二次传播的机会。最终，大乘佛教密宗在青藏高原以及后来的蒙古高原找到了适合自身发展的环境。尽管从形式上说，吐蕃帝国灭亡之后的青藏高原也进入了一种封建状态，但是这里气候毕竟恶劣，世俗政权难以独自完成行政管理重任。在这种条件下，佛教寺院往往就是庞大的封建领主，宗教和宗教组织必须深度参与社会治理，西藏地区的政权或多或少都有政教合一的倾向。当藏传佛教自身需要以统治者的面目出现时，密宗的教义和教法就非常有意义了，而“菩萨救世”的观念有利于让被统治者在思想上顺服。藏传佛教的发展过程中既保留了大乘佛教密宗教义，又设法适应了特殊环境下对于封建社会进行统治的需求，例如所谓活佛转世制度就是这样一种为了维持权力交接稳定而采取的创制。在明代晚期和清代，蒙古牧区也主动或者被动地发展出了一套封建制度（之前已经提过），与藏区的环境相似的是，蒙古牧区同样环境恶劣，地广人稀，行政管理和公共服务都离不开宗教组织。在蒙古地区周边最为适应这种情况的宗教显然就是藏传佛教，因此在俄国干预前的三个世纪里蒙古族普遍信仰藏传佛教就毫不稀奇了，更不要说清朝统治者还一直有意推动这一点。

现在把目光移向上座部佛教，虽然从体量上看大乘佛教流行的地区要远远大于上座部佛教流行的地区，不过上座部佛教的传奇性也丝毫不减。由于斯里兰卡，缅甸，泰国、老挝和柬埔寨这几个国家的传世文献相对于北传佛教诸国少了很多，人们很难准确知道今天的上座部佛教是怎么从部派佛教时期的上座部。今天的上座部佛教和原始的“上座部的佛教”在教义和教法上如何流变？毕竟上座部不可能在公元前的年代就已经能够适应当时还不存在的封建社会。就算现在仍然有散落在世间的文献能够揭示这一点，也不是我在中国通过互联网能够了解的了。上座部佛教的发源地是斯里兰卡，最初阿育王令其子前往此地弘法。有意思的是，尽管上座部佛教伴随斯里兰卡的历史始终，但是斯里兰卡的佛教并非没有发生过变化，我还是在游玩 Paradox《十字军之王3》的一个大型模组“区域沉浸和文化丰富”（Regional Immersion and Cultural Enrichment）才得知的。

最早传入斯里兰卡的佛教派别在日后演变成为大寺派（Mahavihara），这个派别一直坚守上座部的教义。在公元前二世纪，斯里兰卡国王资助建设了无畏山寺，这在后来成为无畏山派（Abhayagiri）中心。这个佛教派别接纳了正在兴起的大乘佛教教义以及更晚的密宗教义，无畏山寺似乎成为大乘佛教的一个中心。后来，无畏山派的其中一支建立了祇陀林寺，在四世纪形成了祇陀林派（Jetavanavihara），这个派别同样弘扬大乘佛教，不过在于大寺派的竞争中似乎更讲策略。从公元三、四世纪开始，斯里兰卡统治者开始有意偏向于无畏山派，佛牙舍利在四世纪被带到斯里兰卡后便供奉在无畏山寺，在接下来几个世



纪间，这里是斯里兰卡主要的学术中心。公元后的第二个千年之初，斯里兰卡面临来自南印度方向越来越严重的军事入侵，笃信印度教的朱罗王朝显然没必要也不会欢迎一个传播古典佛教的大寺院。当斯里兰卡驱逐侵略者恢复独立之后，统治者立刻倒向了大寺派，对于无畏山派和祇陀林派进行了打压，大乘佛教和密宗最终在斯里兰卡消亡了。斯里兰卡佛教派别的实力对比变化是非常有意思的，人们基本上没办法从文献中判断出斯里兰卡在什么时候接近一个古典社会，在什么时候开始走向封建社会。但是三个佛教派别在这么一个不到七万平方公里的岛屿上的兴衰故事如此鲜明地勾勒出了人类社会发展的规律：从早期国家进入了古典社会，又从古典社会迈向了封建社会。

上座部佛教能够在中南半岛占到一席之地离不开地理条件，毕竟缅甸虽然看着与印度和孟加拉挨着，但是路上交通实在是过于艰险，反倒是从南印度和斯里兰卡走海路更容易抵达中南半岛。只要我们姑且承认 11 世纪的时候上座部佛教在教义和教法上已经基本完成了向封建宗教的转变，那么从中国境内南下的缅甸人和傣泰人选择上座部佛教就是毫不奇怪的事情，因为这是他们最熟悉的，也最容易接受的封建宗教。唯一让人感到十分神奇的是柬埔寨，这个国家作为高棉帝国的残余居然也选择了上座部佛教。不过这恰恰是柬埔寨人在古典帝国崩溃时候做出的正确选择之一，另一个正确选择莫过于放弃吴哥迁都金边。高棉统治者因陀罗跋摩三世（Indravarman）做出了皈依上座部佛教这个勇敢的决定，此时帝国已经在泰国人的进攻下风雨飘摇了。作为古典帝国晚期的统治者，虽然不可避免地会感觉到天崩地裂般的灾难，但是能够不被已成为过眼云烟的荣耀所迷惑，主动接纳敌人的宗教，这无论怎么说都是十分了不起的。

（当然，随着高棉社会本身的封建化进程，上座部佛教也在帝国内扩张，因此不能完全说作是“蛮族敌人的宗教”。）后来越南的明命帝入侵老挝和柬埔寨的时候就见识到了上座部佛教在组织民族抵抗上的威力，他因此对上座部佛教恨之入骨，希望在越南人征服的土地上除之而后快。因陀罗跋摩三世确实成功了，虽然古典帝国的瓦解不可避免（而且也应该瓦解），但是柬埔寨人至少保留了高棉帝国的核心区域，现今柬埔寨王室的父系祖先也最远可以追溯到这位勇敢的君主。我认为高棉帝国在谢幕时刻的表现要比拜占庭更好，至少现在吴哥窟还是一个属于柬埔寨的世界遗产和旅游胜地。

最后我们简要看一下夹在两个佛教世界之间的中国西南地区，准确地说，是南诏和大理政权统治时期的中国西南地区。南诏和大理时期的佛教在中国被简称为滇密（Azhaliism，阿吒力教），在形式上看这毫无疑问是密宗的一种，因为它非常提倡秘法修行和走捷径。不过滇密的密不是那种经院式的复杂神秘仪式，而更接近于一些原始信仰的杂糅，同时在戒律上宽松到惊人。这种宗教无论是在南诏这个古典帝国还是在大理这个封建政权都能盛行反映了中国西南山地地区复杂的政治面貌：即使古典国家或者封建国家能够依托崇山峻岭中的有限平原（就是所谓的“坝子”）建立起来，但是周边山区形形色色仍然十分原始的部落是不可能被消灭的，只有工业文明才能做到这一点。事实上如果我们还记得在更早的时候就提到过的大理时期相国高氏掌握权力的情况就不难看出，哪怕大理这个政权本来就是段思平借助东部的各个部落酋长的武装建立的，但是在大理建立之后照样需要在东方防备这些“野人”。无论南诏或者大理的统治者愿不愿意，他们为了避免时时刻刻与这些根本无法消灭的部落处于敌对状态，就必然要在意识形态上做出妥协，滇密就是这样一种宗教。当然我们也不能忘记，当南诏和大理面对中华帝国这个庞然大物时，它们的确存在用一种特有的宗教文化维护自己独立性的需求，滇密也承担了这种功用。如果中国西南地区的封建社会能够走得更远，我们当然有理由相信这里的佛教也会逐渐演变出封建宗教的特征，但是历史显然没有给云南这个机会。

这样一来我们就完成了对于佛教传播历史的一个简单的整体考察，读者到这里显然能够意识到马克思虽然犯了不少错误，但是社会存在决定社会意识实在是一个真知灼见，哪怕他在当年有猜的成分。如果日后的人们能够深入研究宗教教义教法以及其盛行地区的社会结构具有哪些共性，那么很可能真的能够实现这样一个“程序”，我们只需要输入一个社会的有限的状态参数，就可以得到这个社会流行的宗教或



意识形态至少应当具有哪些特征。我们可以怀着复杂的心情承认这一点，虽然在目前看来个人的自由意志还是有的，但是对于社会整体而言，社会意识的表现确实缺乏自由。当一种宗教能够满足一个社会现有发展状态所产生的需求时，那么它就已经占据了社会意识的位置，除非有另一种宗教比它更合适才有可能把它替代掉，否则即使是通过武力弹压也是难以改变的。当这个社会本身发生了变化，那么该社会原先流行的宗教要么适应这种变化进行改变，要么就被一种不知道哪里来的能够适应新情况的宗教所淘汰。我们观察到的事情就是如此，从社会整体上看决定宗教能够在哪里发展的，无非就是两点：适应和先机。同时对于佛教历史的简单梳理，也能够帮助我们更加了解古典时期和封建时期社会意识形态的特征及其演变。

人们或许会指责我考察现今流行于亚洲的宗教比较多但是却没有仔细考察基督教的情况，我解释一下为什么采取这样的方式。第一个原因当然是因为在中国想要了解基督教，不是说大致了解，而是细致了解其发展过程以及各派别之间的差异实在是过于困难。我在 25 年 3 月 8 日号于西安市长安区第三中学考教师资格证考试的时候趁着等待进场的时间逛了一下这个小校园，非常惊讶地发现学校的文化展板上关于西安碑林的《大秦景教流行中国碑》的内容居然也啼笑皆非地使用了拼音。把基督教称为 JD 教，传教士称为 CJ 士，这是取“基督”和“传教”四个字的汉语拼音首字母。这让我感到哭笑不得，景教所属的东方基督教会因为常年处在穆斯林统治下到今天早就已经没什么影响力了，这种莫名其妙的担忧实在是不知所谓。然而我国的宗教政策就是如此，虽然《大秦景教流行中国碑》是中学课本上明确出现的教学内容，但是没有任何人愿意在公共场合犯忌讳，招惹任何不必要的麻烦。如果读者能够深察这一点就自然会理解为什么我想要对基督教进行考察实在是不可能了。第二个原因是我对于西方各国的学者对于基督教的研究水平有充分的信心，即使不谈学术水平，欧美学者因为其生活环境的原因，天然就要比一个东方人对于基督教熟悉得多。虽然现在在搜索和阅读资料的时候存在困难，不过我认为关于基督教发展史以及各流派详细介绍的文章和著作应当早已问世，就没有必要再进行重复工作了。